

Split subject and verb

Some subordinate clauses can be placed in the middle of a sentence, separating the different parts of a main clause. If the subject of a sentence is too far away from its verb,

the meaning of that sentence will be difficult to follow, so long subordinate clauses are best placed at the beginning or end of a sentence.

▷ Separated

This sentence is hard to follow, because the verb, *felt*, is separated from its subject, *Lauren*, by a long subordinate clause.

Lauren, after walking to the café, buying two scoops of ice cream, and eating them hungrily, felt ill.

▷ Reunited

The sentence has been reorganized so that the subject of the main clause, *Lauren*, is now next to its verb.

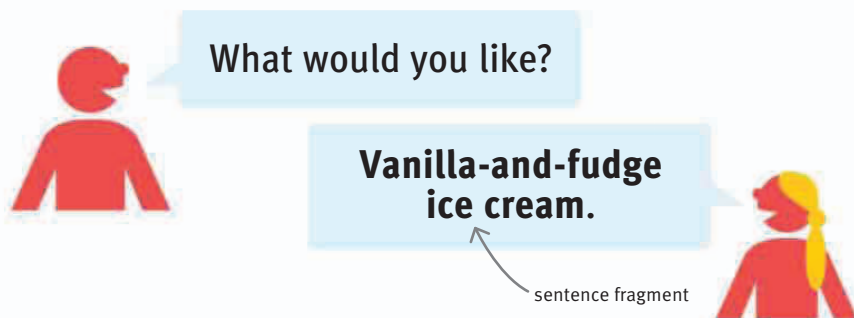
After walking to the café, buying two scoops of ice cream, and eating them hungrily, Lauren felt ill.

Avoiding sentence fragments

Sentence fragments are parts of sentences that do not contain all the pieces needed to make a complete sentence. In the context of a conversation, sentence fragments can be meaningful. Once the context has been removed, however, sentence fragments make no sense at all, so they are rarely used in writing.

▽ Recognizing fragments

Many sentence fragments do not contain a subject or a verb, and they only make sense in context: for example, as the answer to a question.



▽ Making sentences

If a sentence fragment has been removed from its context, the subject and verb need to be reinstated. A written sentence should never have to rely on the sentences around it for its sense.



REAL WORLD

Fragmented advertising

Sentence fragments are often used in advertising, since the product being advertised provides the context. An advertiser's main concern is that the brand is prominent, so the name of this brand normally appears at the start or in the middle of the sentence fragment. Sometimes advertisements are more memorable simply because they sound wrong.

